

ServiceNow Help Desk Lab

Explained in Plain, Simple Words, Updated for the Next Experience UI

What this document is

This is the same lab as before, rewritten so it's easy to follow, step by step, in everyday language. This version has been updated with the exact click-paths and screens found on a real 2026-era PDI (Next Experience UI), based on hands-on testing, including where the doc's original instructions didn't match what actually appears on screen, and what to do instead.

What is a PDI?

PDI stands for Personal Developer Instance. It's your own free, private copy of the full ServiceNow platform, spun up just for you to learn and practice in, nothing you do in it touches a real company's data or configuration.

Think of it like a demo car on a closed test track: it has every feature a real production ServiceNow instance has (Incidents, Problems, Changes, Catalog, Reports, the works), but it's isolated, disposable, and yours alone to experiment with. It even comes pre-loaded with sample data, fake users like “Abel Tuter,” fake tickets, fake hardware records, specifically so you have something to click around and practice on right away.

A few practical things worth knowing about a PDI:

- It's free and doesn't require a credit card. Request it at developer.servicenow.com.
- It runs on a real ServiceNow release version (e.g., Zurich, Australia), so what you learn transfers directly to a paid production instance.
- It hibernates after 10 days of inactivity and gets deleted after 30, so log in weekly to keep it alive.
- Employers and certification paths (like the ITIL exam or a ServiceNow admin cert) often expect hands-on PDI practice as proof of real experience.
- You get admin rights in your own PDI, so you can safely do things (like self-approving a change) that you'd never be allowed to do in a real company instance.
- Not every PDI is configured identically. Which apps and plugins are active, which modules show up in search, and even which report-builder UI you get can vary by instance and release. This doc's screenshots reflect one real instance, so yours may look slightly different, and that's normal.

The Problem This Fixes (in Plain Words)

Imagine a school where anyone can walk up to any teacher and say “my locker is broken.” Three different students tell three different teachers about the SAME broken locker. Now three teachers each think they're the one fixing it, or worse, none of them think it's their job because they assume someone else has it covered. That locker stays broken for days.

That's what happens in a company without a system for tracking IT problems. A server goes down, three employees each tell a different coworker, nobody is officially “assigned” to fix it, and something that should take one hour takes four.

ServiceNow is a piece of software that fixes this. Every problem gets logged as a “ticket” with a tracking number, gets assigned to one specific person, and gets tracked from start (“reported”) to finish (“fixed”). Nothing falls through the cracks because everything is written down in one place.

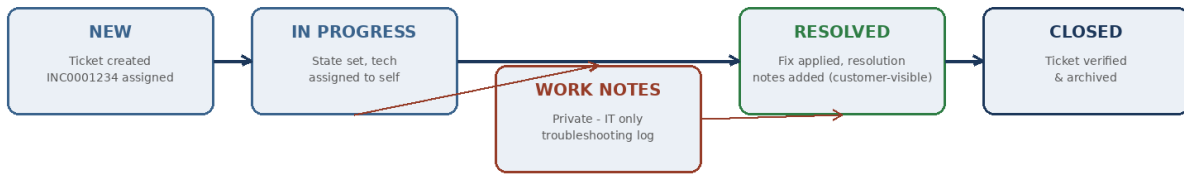
Almost every large company uses ServiceNow or something just like it. Learning it now means you already know how to use the tool before your first day on a help desk job.

Ticket Lifecycle at a Glance

Before diving into the steps, here's the whole incident process in one picture, from the moment something breaks to the moment the ticket is closed.

Incident Ticket Lifecycle

How a reported problem moves from report to resolution in ServiceNow



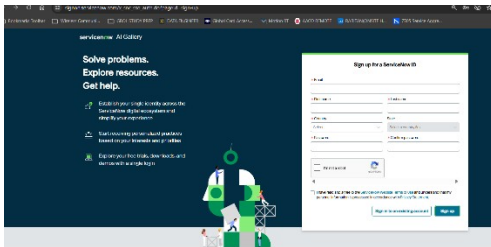
Legend:

- Main ticket state (visible to everyone)
- Private IT documentation step (Work Notes)
- Customer-visible outcome (Resolution Notes)

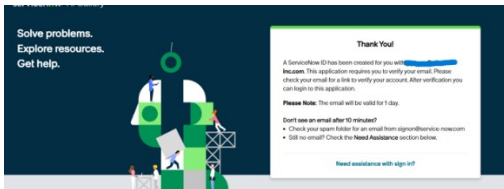
Step 1 , Get Your Free Practice Account

Before you can practice, you need your own PDI to play in.

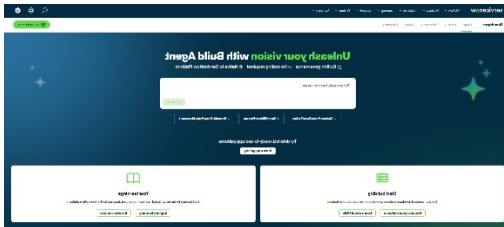
- Open your web browser and go to developer.servicenow.com



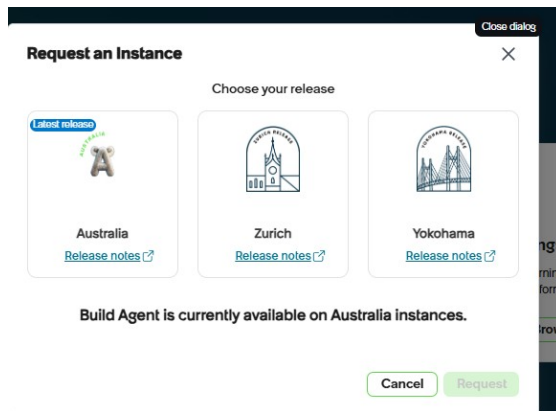
- Click “Sign Up” and make an account using just your email and a password.



- Once logged in, click “Request Instance.”



- Pick the newest version available in the dropdown.



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- Click “Request.” Your instance takes 10 to 15 minutes to provision, like waiting for a game to finish downloading.
- Check your email for your instance URL (e.g., dev12345.service-now.com) plus your username and password.

Don't let it go to sleep!

If you don't log in for 10 days, your PDI hibernates. After 30 days it's deleted completely and you'd have to start over.
Fix: log in at least once a week.

Step 2 , Take a Look Around (Updated Navigation)

On the newer Next Experience UI, the search panel is not sitting open on the left side by default the way it did on older releases. Here's exactly how to get to it.

Opening the search / Filter Navigator

1. Look at the top navigation bar, the row with All, Favorites, History, Workspaces, and Admin, just under the purple browser bookmarks bar.
2. Click directly on the word “All” (top-left, next to the ServiceNow logo).
3. A panel slides out from the left with a search box at the top. This is the Filter Navigator.
4. Type a module name and click the result you want.

Real-world lesson: search smart, not broad

A single generic word like “change” or “report” matches dozens of unrelated modules (Change Password, Exchange Rates, CMDB Reports, Platform Analytics) before it gets anywhere near the module you actually want, and the list can run longer than what fits on screen without scrolling.

Use a more specific phrase instead: “change request” instead of “change,” “reports” (plural) instead of “report.” Scroll all the way down in the results panel , there's often a small down-arrow (▼) at the bottom of the list indicating more results below the visible area.

If a module still doesn't appear after a careful search, it may not be missing , it can be a role-visibility gap (your account's roles don't include the module) or the app/plugin genuinely isn't active on that PDI. A working direct URL to the module's list view (e.g., change_request_list.do) confirms the data model exists even if the nav search doesn't surface it.

Where you click	What it's for
Service Desk → Incidents	Where broken/not-working problems get reported and tracked
Service Desk → Problems	Where you dig into WHY something keeps breaking, not just fix it once
Change → Changes	Where planned updates (like software patches) get approved and scheduled

Service Catalog → Catalogs	The “request form” page where users can ask for things themselves
Reports → Create New	Where you build charts to see what's going on overall

Quick reference: direct short links (if a module isn't in the dropdown)

If any of these don't show up in the Filter Navigator search, whether due to role visibility, a collapsed results group, or a plugin that isn't active, paste the matching link below straight into the browser address bar, replacing devXXXXX with your own instance name. These jump directly to the module's list view, bypassing the search panel entirely.

Module	Direct short link (append to https://devXXXXX.service-now.com/)
Incidents	incident_list.do
Problems	problem_list.do
Changes	change_request_list.do
Service Catalog (storefront)	esc?id=sc_home
Catalog item maintenance	sc_cat_item_list.do
Reports (classic list)	sys_report_list.do
Report Designer (newer builder, if active)	now/report-designer/home
System plugins (to check what's active)	sys_plugins_list.do

A tip on reading these: the last part after the final slash is called a Table Suffix (list.do) , it opens a plain list view of that table's records directly, no menu required. If a link 404s (“Page not found”), that specific table/plugin likely isn't active on your particular PDI rather than the link being wrong , worth trying the equivalent search term first, since naming can vary slightly release to release.

Step 3 , Report and Fix a Problem (an “Incident”)

Part A: Report the problem

Pretend you're the help desk person and someone just called to say their email is broken.

- Click All → type “incident” → click Incidents → click New (top of the list view).
- Short link if Incidents doesn't appear in search: devXXXXX.service-now.com/incident_list.do, then click New at the top of that list.
- Fill out the form:

Box on the form	What to type in it
Caller	Search for “Abel Tuter” and pick that name , he's a fake test user
Category	Software
Subcategory	Email
Short description	User cannot access Outlook , error: Cannot connect to server
Description	User reports Outlook stopped working around 9am. Error: 'Cannot connect to the Exchange server.' No one else affected. User is on Wi-Fi laptop.
Priority	3 , Moderate (only one person affected, webmail workaround available)
Assignment Group	Service Desk

Click Submit, and write down the ticket number (for example, INC0001234). That's how anyone finds this exact ticket again.

Watch what you type into which box

It's easy to type a search term (like “change”) into the wrong field on a form that's already open , for example, into the Service field on an Incident form instead of the top search box. If a field turns red with “Invalid reference,” just clear that field; nothing is saved until you click Submit, so there's no harm done.

Part B: Actually work the ticket

- Open the incident you just made.
- Change “State” to “In Progress.” This tells everyone else someone's already on it.
- Click “Assigned to” and type your own username.
- Add a Work Note (private, IT staff only).

Work Note (private, IT staff only)

Contacted user. Confirmed error message. Outlook profile appears corrupted. Attempting profile repair. Instructed user to use OWA (webmail) in the interim. Resolution ETA: 30 minutes.

- Once fixed, add Resolution Notes (customer-visible):

Resolution Notes (customer can see this)

Rebuilt Outlook profile. Removed and re-added the Exchange account. User confirmed Outlook is working. Issue was a corrupted OST file. Closed with user confirmation.

- Change the State to “Resolved,” then “Closed.”

Think of Work Notes as sticky notes on the file that only coworkers see, and Resolution Notes as the final “here's what we did” note that goes to the customer.

Step 4 , Build a Self-Service Request Form

A “service catalogue item” is basically an online order form, like ordering food from an app instead of calling a restaurant.

- Click All → type “catalog” → click Maintain Items → New.
- Short link if Maintain Items doesn't appear in search: devXXXXXX.service-now.com/sc_cat_item_list.do, then click New at the top of that list.

Box on the form	What to type in it
Name	New Laptop Request
Category	Hardware
Short description	Request a new or replacement laptop
Description	Use this form to request a new laptop for a new hire or to replace a failed or end-of-life device. Requests reviewed within 2 business days. Delivery 5 to 7 business days after approval.
Fulfillment group	IT Hardware Team
Price	Leave blank , no charge for internal requests

- Click Submit to save it, then open the “Variables” tab to add the blank fields employees will fill in:

Field name	Type of field / required?
Requester Name	One line of text , required

Field name	Type of field / required?
Business Justification	A paragraph of text , required
Required By Date	A date picker , required
Laptop Model Preference	Dropdown: Standard, Developer, Executive , optional

- Click “Save and Preview.” Your form now shows up in the request portal.

Step 5 , Get a Manager's Sign-Off Before a Big Change (Updated Navigation)

Some changes are risky if nobody double-checks them first. That's why big changes need approval before any work starts, like a permission slip before a field trip.

If “Change” doesn't show up in search

Try searching “change request” instead of just “change.” If it's still not visible in the nav panel, go directly to the list view by typing this into the browser address bar: `dev[yourinstance].service-now.com/change_request_list.do` , then click New at the top of that list. A working list here confirms the module exists even if search doesn't surface it for your role.

- Go to Change → Changes → New (Standard).

Box on the form	What to type in it
Short description	Deploy security patch MS24-001 to all Windows workstations
Category	Software
Risk	Low
Impact	2 , Medium
Start date	Next Saturday at 2:00 AM
End date	Next Saturday at 6:00 AM
Description	Monthly security patch deployment. Patch addresses CVE-2024-0001 rated CVSS 7.8. Workstations require one reboot. Deployed via WSUS. Rollback: uninstall via WSUS if issues reported.

- Click the “Planning” tab and fill in a Test Plan and Backout Plan.
- Click “Request Approval” to move it into “Pending Approval.”
- Go to the “Approvals” tab and approve it yourself (you're the admin here).
- The change moves to “Scheduled,” meaning it's approved and waiting for its time.

Step 6 , Build a Chart / Report (Updated for the Wizard-Style Report Builder)

Newer instances use a guided report builder with four tabs across the top: Data → Type → Configure → Style. Here's the walkthrough matched to that exact screen.

Getting to the report builder

Click All → type “reports” (plural) → look for a Reports section and click Create New.

If Reports doesn't appear in search, try the URL: `dev[yourinstance].service-now.com/sys_report_list.do` → click New.

Note: the newer “Report Designer” drag-and-drop tool (`now/report-designer/home`) is a separate, newer builder not active on every instance , if that URL 404s, use the classic wizard described below instead; both accomplish the same result.

Tab 1: Data

5. Report name: type “Incident Volume by Priority, Last 30 Days.”
6. Source type: leave as “Data source.”
7. Data source: click the dropdown and choose the plain “Incidents.Open (Incident)” option, not one of the entries prefixed “PA.Source” (those are Performance Analytics sources with extra SLA-specific filters already baked in, which you don’t want here).

How to tell you picked the right data source

Once selected, the left panel should show Table: Incident and Applied conditions: Active = true , nothing about SLA, Stage, or Opened dates. If you see SLA-related conditions listed, you picked a Performance Analytics source by mistake; reopen the dropdown and pick the plain Incident option instead.

Tab 2: Type

- Click the “Type” tab and choose Bar Chart from the gallery.

Tab 3: Configure

- Group by: set to Priority.
- Aggregation: leave as Count.
- Click the “All” filter link under the data source conditions to open Incident Conditions.
- Set the field to Created, the operator to at or after, then click the value box to open the relative date picker.
- In the date picker, expand DAYS and look for a “Last 30 days” preset; if only Last 90 days (or another interval) is offered, either keep it and adjust the report name/title to match, or manually enter 30 in a numeric days field if one is available.
- Leave the condition set to combine with AND (not OR) alongside the existing Active = true condition.

Tab 4: Style (optional)

- Adjust chart color, size, and axis labels if desired. This is purely cosmetic.

Finish

- Double-check the Report Title at the top and the Report Name field match your chosen date range (e.g., both say “Last 30 Days,” not a leftover “Last 90 Days”).
- Click Run (top-right) to preview the bar chart.
- Click Save.

For extra practice, build two more charts: Mean Time to Resolution (MTTR) by team, and Open Incidents by Assigned Agent , same Data → Type → Configure → Style flow, different Group by and data source.

Words You'll Hear a Lot (in Plain English)

Term	What it actually means
Incident	Something broke and needs fixing NOW. Goal: restore service fast.
Problem	The deeper reason something keeps breaking. Goal: fix the root cause.
Change	A planned update or modification, done carefully to avoid a new outage.
Service Request	Someone asking for something NEW , not something broken.
SLA	Service Level Agreement , a promise on response/resolution time.

Term	What it actually means
CMDB	Configuration Management Database , every piece of tech the company owns.
Knowledge Base	Library of “here's how we fixed this before” articles.
PDI	Personal Developer Instance , your free, private ServiceNow sandbox.
Filter Navigator	The search box (opened via the All menu) used to jump to any module by typing its name.
For your portfolio Take a screenshot of: your completed ticket (with the work note and resolution), your new laptop request form, the approved change request, and one of your charts. For each screenshot, write 2 to 3 sentences in your own words explaining what it does and why it matters , and consider adding a short note on how you navigated a UI that didn't match a written SOP exactly, since troubleshooting mismatched documentation is itself a real help desk skill worth demonstrating.	